

Step 1 · The problem, evidenced

Two hours. You are not starting a research project — you are raising the brief you already wrote to the line the scorecard draws at Evidence, 25 points.

1 — 2 — 3

WHERE THIS GETS YOU · STEP 1 OF 3

When this is done you hold: a one-page brief with a falsifiable problem sentence, 3 to 5 links that open for a stranger, 2 to 3 verbatim quotes including one that disagrees, one killed theme, and judgement line 1 of 3. **Banked: Evidence, 25 points. Carries into C.3:** the brief gets pasted in as context before you prompt for anything, so the spec argues from your users instead of the industry average.

THE GATE · HAVE THESE THREE, OR YOU ARE STARTING A RESEARCH PROJECT INSTEAD

FROM C.1

The Rowan pack + the CSV

Both open beside you. The memo already carries a conclusion: treat it as a claim to check.

YOU FIND THESE

3 or 4 people to interview

Anyone who cancelled a subscription app. Ask around tonight; twenty minutes each is plenty.

FROM C.1

The one sentence

This prototype settles whether _____. Cannot write it? You are still exploring, not building.

THE FOUR MOVES · 2 HOURS · SET A TIMER PER MOVE

1 Fix the decision 20 MIN

Not "users find scheduling frustrating." **Instead:** [who, specifically] does [what], [how often], and it costs them [time, money or errors]. Mark every guessed number with a [?] now. You will source it in move 2 or delete it in move 4.

WORKED ON SLOTLINE · YOUR CAPSTONE IS ROWAN

"Ops coordinators at 50–200 person companies book cross-team meetings 8–12 times a week, each taking 3 to 4 round-trips because availability lives in three places — about 80 minutes a week each." Falsifiable, not atmosphere.

2 The outside claim 35 MIN · LIVE SEARCH, NOT MEMORY

Every market or competitor claim gets a source that clicks back to the page making it. Grade each: a **vendor page** proves they claim it, not that it is true. An **analyst survey** proves a population reported it, not that your users behave that way. A **review** proves one real person hit this. Check the year chain too.

PASTE THIS

Role: research assistant for a PM who will defend every number in front of a VP. **Task:** for the claim below, find current sources; give the specific page, the publication date, and what the source actually measured. **Format:** a table. **Guardrails:** if you cannot find a source, say "no source found" and stop. Do not substitute a similar statistic from another market or year. Flag anything older than 24 months.

3 The inside evidence 35 MIN · NO QUOTE, NO THEME

A theme with no verbatim under it is a sentence you wrote wearing a user's clothes. Then run the counter-prompt and kill whatever does not survive it. **Keep the dissenting quote** — one line of disagreement shows you read the data instead of mining it.

THE PASS, THEN THE COUNTER-PASS

Give me the 3 strongest themes across these transcripts. Under each, quote 2 verbatim lines with the participant number. Do not paraphrase a quote into the theme's language; if a theme has only one participant, say so. Use nothing outside these files.
— then —

What contradicts each theme you just gave me? Quote the lines that disagree, and tell me which theme is weakest.

4 Write it to the standard 30 MIN

Six sections: **Problem** · **Evidence** (3–5 sourced claims + 2–3 verbatim quotes) · **Who, and how many** (arithmetic shown) · **White space** · **Recommendation** · **Still unsure**. That last section costs nothing and buys credibility.

SELF-CHECK · EVIDENCE, 25 PTS

- ☐ Problem names **who**, **how often**, and **what it costs**
- ☐ Every number has a source, or shows its arithmetic
- ☐ At least one **verbatim quote you did not write**
- ☐ Every link opens for a stranger, at the page that makes the claim
- ☐ One theme killed or downgraded, and you can say why

users are frustrated

one invented statistic

FOR ROWAN

"Not using it" is a symptom. 45% of the exit survey picks it; the interviews are where you find out what it means.

The memo's 20-point pause gap is a claim. Check how it was measured before you build on it.

Do not ask why they cancelled. Ask about the last week they used it.

STEP 1 · JUDGEMENT LINE

What the AI got wrong here, and what I did about it: